

Late birds

Although most dinosaurs disappeared 65 million years ago, birds continued to flourish. During the Cenozoic—the era that followed the age of the dinosaurs—birds evolved into a vast range of new species. Some became masters of the sky or took to the water. Others gave up flying and evolved into huge carnivores, filling the gap that the dinosaurs had left open.

Titanis

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- **When** 5–2 million years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** North and South America
- **Habitat** Grassy plains
- **Height** 8 ft (2 m)
- **Diet** Meat

Also known as a “terror bird,” *Titanis* was a gigantic, flightless carnivore as fearsome as a dinosaur. It was twice the weight of a man but much faster, capable of running at up to perhaps 40 mph (65 kph). It used a huge, hooked beak to kill prey and rip open their bodies. *Titanis* lived at the same time as prehistoric humans were beginning to walk on land and spread, but the two never met as *Titanis* lived only in the Americas. Among its prey was the prehistoric horse *Hipparion*.